

Key Actions to Succeed as a Head of Infrastructure Platforms

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Initiatives: Transform Cloud Strategy for Disruptive Platform Demands; Technologies and Markets

The head of infrastructure platforms faces challenges in aligning initiatives with business goals and managing resistance to change. Use this guidance to adopt strategies for stakeholder engagement, role clarity, and quick wins to enhance infrastructure maturity and early success in your role.

Overview

Key Findings

- The growing need to meet end-user agility and provide enterprise systems reliability has spotlighted the need for infrastructure platforms and teams to build, manage and operate these platforms. Associated with that is a demand for infrastructure platforms leaders within I&O.
- Although many infrastructure platforms leaders have a traditional infrastructure background, most do not have the product management skills required to succeed in their role.
- The head of infrastructure platforms faces challenges when they do not adequately manage their department's resistance to change, fail to communicate how infrastructure initiatives support larger IT goals, and do not incorporate business priorities into the infrastructure initiatives.
- Early success in this role depends on three achievements: (1) establishing credibility and leadership, (2) assuring hesitant stakeholders about the value of adopting a platforms-oriented approach and (3) defining clear steps to advance the organization's infrastructure maturity.

Recommendations

- Develop an understanding of the cultural and political aspects of the organization's current IT environment. Build strong ties with key stakeholders to ensure that colleagues — the application development community and internal partners within business units — recognize and appreciate your position and responsibilities.
- Firmly define the role and scope of responsibilities so that you are seen as a strategic leader, rather than simply as an administrator or back-office “catch-all.”
- Weigh the department's current level of infrastructure maturity, especially in automation and self-service enablement areas, which are the most customer-facing.
- Create a strategy that delivers major priorities and gains the broader IT community's support by executing on quick wins that favorably impact the enterprise.

Introduction

Infrastructure platforms engineering and operating is a relatively new but rapidly growing field. Candidates from diverse backgrounds — such as infrastructure, application development and program management — can possess competencies required to succeed as heads of infrastructure platforms.

Infrastructure platform engineering is the discipline of building internal infrastructure platform software products that present IT infrastructure to users or other platforms in an easily consumable way. Infrastructure platforms are self-service tools that allow nonexpert users to deploy and manage infrastructure themselves while I&O retains governance, security and compliance, which are used as the foundation of higher-order, self-service layers, such as internal developer platforms.

If this position is new to you, do not be intimidated by a lack of experience working in this domain. Take time to transition into the role, set expectations and make a strong first impression.

Use this guidance to:

- Establish your credibility as the head of infrastructure platforms and build relationships with your manager, peers (both your peers and your boss' peers), direct reports and key consumers of infrastructure platforms.

- Determine the current infrastructure maturity of your organization. Formulate a vision and plan for how to advance it while influencing others.
- Demonstrate your leadership management style. Define realistic, measurable, time-bound goals, and establish metrics to track progress.
- Gain support by executing a quick win that positively impacts the overall enterprise. Overcome obstacles such as experiencing resistance to change from existing I&O personnel, and avoid pitfalls such as a lack of emphasis on business priorities.

Refer to this downloadable tool for a comprehensive summary of each action, including target outcomes, actionable solutions to overcome barriers and strategies for communication.

[A Sample Action Plan for the Head of Infrastructure Platforms](#)

Use the table below to navigate this research. See Notes section for more resources on each action.

Table 1: Simple Table

(Enlarged table in Appendix)

Actions	Activities
Prepare before starting your role	■ Educate yourself of the core activities and expectations. ■ Foster strong relationships with business stakeholders.
Assess and plan to determine your infrastructure group's operations and priorities	■ Determine the infrastructure group's culture and appetite for change. ■ Understand the day-to-day operations. ■ Communicate updates with cross-functional stakeholders. ■ Review your observations and share lessons with the team and manager. ■ Determine your organization's immediate priorities.
Act to deliver results and measure progress to refine long-term strategy	■ Establish ways to measure your progress. ■ Clarify team roles and individual deliverables and strengthen relationships. ■ Execute a quick win. ■ Reflect on progress to course-correct long-term plans. ■ Share success with the infrastructure platforms group to build confidence in leadership.

Source: Gartner

Analysis

To succeed as the head of infrastructure platforms, take concrete steps before and after starting your role.

Prepare Before Starting Your Role

Plan for your new role before your first day because of your role's potentially broad mandate. Understand your team and group culture to foster strong relationships with business stakeholders across departments.

To make an impact quickly, you should aim to:

- Understand the broader infrastructure group's vision, strategy and culture, so you know how to approach your role.
- Align your expectations with the infrastructure organization's goals to clarify role expectations.
- Gain insights into your organization's current capabilities and its role within the overall infrastructure community.
- Build a clear communication plan for your first day, including a drafted introductory message.

Actionable Solutions to Overcome Barriers

The inability to prepare beforehand will lead to reduced interaction with key staff and understanding of macro organizational goals (for example, the entire enterprise, IT, the larger infrastructure group, etc.). To mitigate this:

- Get a list of peers or stakeholders and connect via a business-appropriate social media platform, such as LinkedIn. Learn about their backgrounds and set up introductory calls. Connect with as many key members of your group as possible, particularly the most senior infrastructure subject matter experts (SMEs) and your predecessor (if you have one).

- Educate yourself on your organization's overall IT goals and how infrastructure platforms contribute to them to build a strong foundation for next steps. To achieve this:
 - Learn about your organization's industry and the current state of the market to anticipate where the organization might lean.
 - Educate yourself on your role's core activities and expectations to avoid scope creep later. Don't allow stakeholders to offload administrative work onto you or dictate your priorities.
 - Meet with your predecessor and manager, if possible, to ensure a smooth transition. Review your job description, the makeup of the infrastructure group and the reporting structure with your manager to set your own strategy. Talk with your team to understand responsibilities that were not addressed by the predecessor that your manager may be unaware of.
 - Learn how the head of infrastructure platforms role supports the overall IT goals and strategy, including the metrics for success, span of control and the role's level of influence.
 - Reflect on your background — such as infrastructure engineering, infrastructure operations, application development and program management — to know your strengths and weaknesses. Recognize how your previous experience may affect understanding of the infrastructure platforms mandate to avoid pitfalls.

Communication Strategies

Focus on effective communication — not decision making — to learn about the infrastructure group. Prepare and deliver messages for your team and the group at large through in-person or virtual meet-and-greet meetings. To communicate effectively:

- Assess your communication skills:
 - Use clear, prescriptive and specific language wherever possible. Avoid ambiguous jargon and platitudes. Avoid generic statements — for example, “business agility” and “customer enablement” — and focus on what is specific to your organization’s performance.
 - Define any specialist terms — such as technical abbreviations and acronyms (for example, infrastructure as code [IaC], FinOps) — when speaking with nonexperts.
 - Be brief and consistent in your messaging across forums and audiences.
 - Connect plans explicitly to the enterprise’s strategic investment objectives, demonstrating that the infrastructure platforms organization is synchronized with the business.
 - Share your plans with IT peers and business leaders throughout the organization and actively solicit feedback.
- Prepare introductory communication:
 - Prepare a fact-based, neutral and succinct introduction about yourself, your background and your goals for the function.
 - Deliver this message in advance, and communicate timelines for progress updates.

- Stakeholder interaction:
 - Draft discussion guides with open-ended and specific questions to organize productive stakeholder and staff discussions. For example, ask key business stakeholders about their perception of and satisfaction with the infrastructure group; any issues that must be resolved as quickly as possible; and key work challenges, priorities and general expectations.
 - Avoid scope creep by reaching out to stakeholders, such as infrastructure engineering leaders (compute, networking, storage), infrastructure and operations managers (Level 1, Level 2), application developers, database administrators (DBAs) and enterprise architecture leaders.
 - During the interaction, let the meeting members introduce themselves and ask questions that they might have.
- Identify team's needs and technical challenges:
 - Assess technical onboarding challenges.
 - Understand your direct reports' concerns, priorities and career aspirations over a period of time.
- Meet your manager:
 - Communicate key challenges and opportunities from your point of view.
 - Discuss initial priorities for improvement areas.
 - Establish a communication schedule between you and your manager.

Assess and Plan to Determine Your Infrastructure Group's Operations and Priorities

After starting the role, focus on the day-to-day activities and operations of the infrastructure group.

Assess your department's culture and appetite for change to know how to approach new initiatives. Identify department members who may either resist change or want change, including more responsibility. Loop them in early to get their support. Interact with cross-functional stakeholders and define your role with them.

Review what you have observed so far and share key teaching points with your manager and the rest of the infrastructure platforms team (that is, your direct reports). Determine your organization's immediate priorities.

To achieve this outcome:

- Conduct a maturity assessment that identifies the top priorities and potential quick wins.
- Develop a new infrastructure platforms strategy based on the new information collected and maturity-assessment results.
- Align with stakeholders and confirm the actionability of your plans as outlined in your strategy.

Actionable Solutions to Overcome Barriers

While assessing your department, the inability to fully understand key aspects of your infrastructure platforms team — such as operational processes, norms and level of investment or budget — may emerge as a major barrier.

To avoid these pitfalls:

- Conduct a listening tour to connect with your manager and internal stakeholders in departments such as infrastructure engineering, infrastructure operations, application development and enterprise architecture. These meetings will allow you to deeply examine:
 - Company norms and department operations, processes, protocol and workflow.
 - Stakeholders' receptiveness to change.
- Evaluate the group's budget and headcount allocation to set realistic goals and inform your strategic planning (see [Tool: Budget Challenge and Cost Mitigation Tracker for I&O Leaders](#)). Identify any major changes related to budget or headcount in the last few years, or if they've remained constant.
- Gauge your staff's skills and the quality of existing infrastructure platforms or tools. Determine areas related to skills and platforms that you can address early in your tenure (see [How to Develop Infrastructure Platform Engineering Teams](#)).

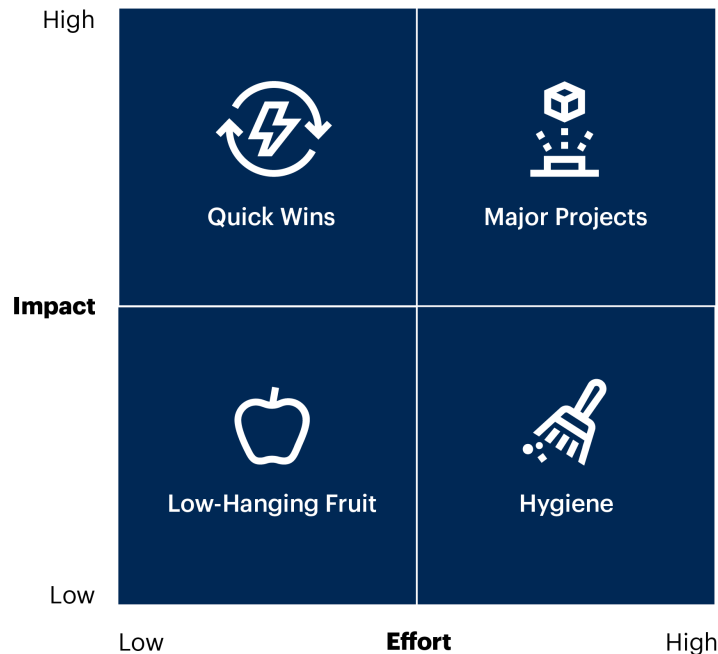
- Identify all infrastructure processes, starting with processes that are used to request and consume infrastructure services. Determine which ones to include in an upcoming maturity assessment.

While determining your organization's priorities, avoid under-/overshooting expectations. Undershooting expectations can prevent you from building credibility if your activities are not impactful. Overshooting expectations can totally derail your efforts with early and visible failures. Misalignment with business priorities may also become a barrier.

To enable success:

- Compare your department's operational maturity against its peers and rate yourself based on the information (see [IT Score for Infrastructure and Operations](#)).
- Refine or design a new infrastructure platforms strategy. If your team has an existing strategy, review the documentation and update the strategy from there. If your team does not have a strategy, draft one using the information gathered from your stakeholder meetings and maturity-assessment results.
- Select two to three key issues to address first. Understand what you were brought in to do, and identify your main focus areas with your manager. Balance your department's biggest pain points and tasks. Identify issues that can be addressed quickly to demonstrate results. Consider using a grid, as depicted in Figure 1, to identify items that are quick wins. Some examples of these projects include:
 - Creating a rewards and recognition program.
 - Developing self-service tools for business units.
 - Creating an infrastructure platforms intranet with product descriptions and FAQs.

Figure 1: Prioritization Matrix

Prioritization Matrix

Source: Gartner
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Gartner**Communication Strategies**

Follow these best practices to communicate your assessment of the department's culture and organizational priorities:

- Familiarize yourself with the different communications channels used by your organization.
- Establish a clear line of communication between yourself, your manager and direct reports through ongoing meetings and check-ins. Set up meetings with different group members of the infrastructure group to understand their experience.
- Clearly communicate your preliminary strategy and expectations for the next three, six and 12 months. Describe:
 - Where the infrastructure platforms group is now and where it should be. Also consider why it should be there and when it will get there.
 - What obstacles need to be overcome and what gaps need to be filled to get there.

- What persistent operational issues need focused attention to get done.
- Seek feedback on your plans from different levels and departments within the IT community to confirm its actionability and get buy-in.

Act to Deliver Results and Measure Progress to Refine Long-Term Strategy

Establish how you will measure your progress, clarify team roles and individual deliverables, strengthen relationships, and execute a quick win. Additionally, take time to reflect on your progress so far. Determine what worked and what didn't, and adjust your long-term plans accordingly. Share your success with the whole infrastructure group to increase confidence in your leadership, but avoid overly embellishing or seeming boastful. To achieve this:

- Communicate your strategy and improve processes or projects. Identify key metrics to track and document progress on initiatives.
- Establish relationships with internal teams and outside partners, such as cloud partners and infrastructure software vendors.
- Enhance department-wide understanding of the value that you will bring to different practice areas.
- Provide evidence of early progress along with an initial status report for your direct manager and senior executives.
- Self-reflect on the lessons learned thus far and plan for future improvement. Develop a strategic plan that includes all necessary changes.

Actionable Solutions to Overcome Barriers

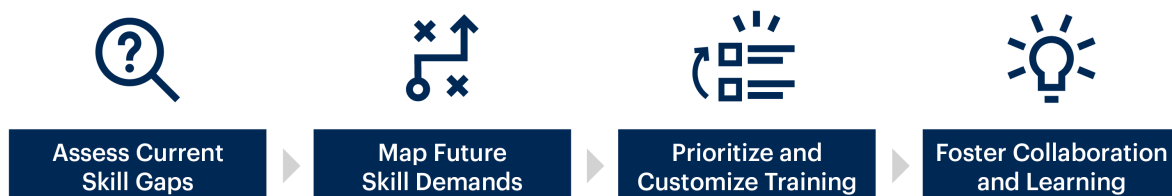
When delivering results, the inability to know what good looks like may create a barrier. This requires well-defined metrics, which determine what initiatives you can start alongside personnel assignments. Lack of governance and adaptability when evaluating current progress may also pose a challenge. To avoid these barriers:

- Establish and maintain documentation and metrics to identify the metrics you will use to track progress on each of your initiatives (see [Use These Metrics to Improve I&O's Value](#)). Evaluate the success of completed projects. Make a list of lessons you've learned so far based on any challenges faced.

- Execute any new process improvements that are quick fixes, including new technology and automation tools.
- Evaluate your department's relationships with external entities (internal business groups, vendors, etc.) which can contribute to your overall platforms strategy.
- Begin to establish strong talent-management practices (see [Four Actions to Grow and Retain Your Top Talent](#)). Identify what skills your team needs to develop, and take stock of current levels of engagement. Commence work on a training strategy (see Figure 2) focusing on the four areas listed.

Figure 2: Training Strategy

Training Strategy



Source: Gartner
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Gartner

- Prepare plans for staff restructuring or reassignment. If you have a larger team, you can work with HR to see if it has engagement survey results or exit interview data that it can share with you.
- Clarify team roles and objectives. Work with your direct reports to make sure their written job descriptions accurately reflect their day-to-day responsibilities.
- Review and summarize what you have observed so far, including where your organization stands in terms of infrastructure maturity. Write a synopsis of what you've accomplished and share what metrics you will be using to track your progress and update your plans going forward.
- Work with your manager to decide how you will communicate progress going forward. For example, provide updates during department meetings or give presentations on new processes and technology implementations.

Communication Strategies

Follow these communication strategies to deliver results and measure progress:

- Regularly communicate your progress with your manager, direct reports and key stakeholders via one-on-one meetings, email, quarterly updates and town hall meetings. Highlight quick wins and share any future initiatives you have planned, such as through an internal newsletter or at a department meeting. Ensure that the infrastructure platforms team understands your plans and strategic goals and is able to support you along the way:
 - Manager: Keep your manager in the loop so they can support you and assist with change management and clearing barriers.
 - Direct reports: Continuously update your direct reports on your progress to establish trust so you can provide coaching and management later on. Your direct reports can be a good resource if you're unsure about how certain department processes work.
 - Peers: Let them know when you want them to weigh in.
 - Business partners outside IT: Leverage their support to help you execute on any quick wins. Continue to foster strong communication so you can ensure their support.
- Meet infrastructure department members who may either resist change or want change. Understand their concerns and work to mitigate them. Reassure them and get buy-in for upcoming projects.
- Foster strong communications channels where infrastructure employees can effectively voice concerns about pain points or issues with workflow or processes:
 - Finalize communication best practices with your direct reports and your manager.
 - Establish channels for employees outside of the infrastructure team.

Evidence

This note is a foundational Gartner research for Platform Leaders.

Notes

Table 2: Simple Table
(Enlarged table in Appendix)

Key Actions	Resources
Action 1: Prepare Before Starting Your Role	Gartner Research and Tools: ■ Video: Demystify Infrastructure Platform Engineering ■ How to Address the Cloud Skills Gap Within I&O ■ Effective Communications: How to Develop a Communications Plan (this document is for CIOs but has content that is applicable for infrastructure platforms managers) Other Suggested Resources: ■ Company and industry websites. View these to develop an understanding of the fundamentals of your employer's industry. ■ Job sites. Read job descriptions of similar roles at other companies to gain a deeper understanding of the typical duties of the head of infrastructure platforms. You can also assess how many other infrastructure positions are open in the company to obtain an early indication of whether the group is expanding or has high staff turnover in any areas. ■ Professional associations and networking sites. Connect with other professionals in similar roles and familiarize yourself with the resources offered to the head of infrastructure platforms. ■ Organizational chart and reporting structure. Use these tools to give yourself an overview of who you will be working with, both directly and indirectly.
Action 2: Assess Your Infrastructure Group's Activities and Operations	Gartner Research and Tools: ■ Hype Cycle for Infrastructure Platforms, 2024 ■ Hype Cycle for I&O Automation, 2024 ■ What Good Modern Infrastructure Looks Like ■ Drive Business Agility With Infrastructure Platform Engineering ■ Tool: Peer-Based Diagnostic For Best-in-Class Infrastructure ■ Designing a Platform-Oriented I&O Operating Model ■ How to Develop Infrastructure Platform Engineering Teams ■ I&O Platforms Primer for 2025 ■ I&O Organizational Strategy Primer for 2025 ■ I&O Operations Management Primer for 2025 ■ Digital Workplace Infrastructure and IT Operations Primer for 2025 ■ Inquiries with Gartner analysts around infrastructure maturity for similar-sized companies, possibly within the same industry. Other Suggested Resources: ■ Existing infrastructure strategy documents. If your predecessor documented their plans and priorities, review those to gain a better understanding of where the department was and where it is going. ■ Minutes from recent infrastructure meetings. Read these notes to identify the infrastructure group's main priorities and the focus of key stakeholders. ■ Project calendar or agenda. Use this information to see any technology or process implementations that are already planned. ■ Documentation for existing processes. Understand the maturity level of your organization and provide material required for growth. ■ List challenges. Review this list with your trusted stakeholders and manager as they are invested in your success and should be able to help you navigate these challenges. ■ Department budget for the current year and previous year. This will allow you to gauge year-over-year changes and areas of increased or decreased emphasis.
Action 3: Act to deliver results and measure progress to refine long-term strategy	Gartner Research and Tools: ■ How to Start and Scale Your Platform Engineering Team ■ How to Leverage Platform Engineering Principles to Deliver Infrastructure Platforms ■ Modernizing Infrastructure Platforms and Operating Models in Support of Digital Foundations ■ Case Study: Communication Strategies to Demonstrate I&O Value

Source: Gartner

Document Revision History

The Head of Infrastructure Platforms' First 100 Days - 18 September 2023

Recommended by the Author

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

[How to Leverage Platform Engineering Principles to Deliver Infrastructure Platforms](#)

Modernizing Infrastructure Platforms and Operating Models in Support of Digital Foundations

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Act to deliver results and measure progress to refine long-term strategy	■ Establish ways to measure your progress. ■ Clarify team roles and individual deliverables and strengthen relationships. ■ Execute a quick win. ■ Reflect on progress to course-correct long-term plans.

- Share success with the infrastructure platforms group to build confidence in leadership.

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indirectly.

Action 2: Assess Your Infrastructure Group's Activities and Operations

Gartner Research and Tools:

- [Hype Cycle for Infrastructure Platforms, 2024](#)
- [Hype Cycle for I&O Automation, 2024](#)
- [What Good Modern Infrastructure Looks Like](#)
- [Drive Business Agility With Infrastructure Platform Engineering](#)
- [Tool: Peer-Based Diagnostic For Best-in-Class Infrastructure](#)
- [Designing a Platform-Oriented I&O Operating Model](#)
- [How to Develop Infrastructure Platform Engineering Teams](#)

- [I&O Platforms Primer for 2025](#)
- [I&O Organizational Strategy Primer for 2025](#)
- [I&O Operations Management Primer for 2025](#)
- [Digital Workplace Infrastructure and IT Operations Primer for 2025](#)
- [Inquiries with Gartner analysts around infrastructure maturity for similar-sized companies, possibly within the same industry.](#)

Other Suggested Resources:

- **Existing infrastructure strategy documents.** If your predecessor documented their plans and priorities, review those to gain a better understanding of where the department was and where it is going.

- **Minutes from recent infrastructure meetings.** Read these notes to identify the infrastructure group's main priorities and the focus of key stakeholders.
- **Project calendar or agenda.** Use this information to see any technology or process implementations that are already planned.
- **Documentation for existing processes.** Understand the maturity level of your organization and provide material required for growth.
- **List challenges.** Review this list with your trusted stakeholders and manager as they are invested in your success and should be able to help you navigate these challenges.
- **Department budget for the current year and previous year.** This will allow you to gauge year-over-year changes and areas of increased or decreased emphasis.

Action 3: Act to deliver results and measure progress to refine long-term strategy

Gartner Research and Tools:

- [How to Start and Scale Your Platform Engineering Team](#)
- [How to Leverage Platform Engineering Principles to Deliver Infrastructure Platforms](#)
- [Modernizing Infrastructure Platforms and Operating Models in Support of Digital Foundations](#)
- [Case Study: Communication Strategies to Demonstrate I&O Value](#)

Source: Gartner